

CONTEMPORARIES OF ISSACHAR

I Chronicles 12:32 “And of the children of Issachar, which were men that had understanding of the times, to know what Israel ought to do; the heads of them were two hundred; and all their brethren were at their commandment.”

INTRO: We live in a very solemn, desperate hour. The Church, our country, and our world have a real need for the young people coming out of our religious institutions to be powerful for GOD!

I am convinced that God is not through with the Assemblies of God, but that He wants to do something in us, and then through us, the likes of which the world has never seen!

How can we be powerful for GOD? First of all it is essential that His Word abide in us, for our response to that Word will determine our usefulness and fruitfulness.

In studying the context of this passage, we learn that the paramount purpose in the minds of the people is the proper recognition of the king. Of course, the reference is to King David, which was God's plan and purpose at the time.

The spiritual counterpart for our time is not unlike that of Israel. Today our main goal and primary purpose is the proper recognition of our King - **“even the root and the offspring of David.”** For this we pray, plan, and labor.

Our teaching, our sermonizing and gospelization, both domestic and foreign, should be geared to bringing people into the kingdom of heaven.

I'm afraid that the tragic declines we have seen within this great fellowship in the last few years, can be directly tied to the **“HOLD**

THE FORT” philosophy.

My prayer is that the God of Heaven will deliver us from the temptation of being mediocre, average, or laid back, and cause us to rise and build a Church that is intentionally evangelistic! I Timothy 2:3-4 **“For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Savior; who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth.”**

Whether we want to admit it or not the Great Commission of Christ to the Church is still

Mark 16:15 **“And he said unto them, Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.”** This is the Great Commission, not the Great Suggestion!

God, would you give us some **“CONTEMPORARIES OF ISSACHAR”** in every church in this Fellowship?

Young people, I pray that you will make up your mind right now to quit **“HOLDING THE FORT”**, and set about the business of preparing our strategy for **“STORMING THE FORT”**!

Let me sound an alarm here, however. We must maintain this purpose without compromising our message. If the message is lost, then all is lost.

There is a subtle and erroneous teaching abroad today that the end justifies the means. This is both portrayed and verbalized on the screen, in the marketplace, in the home and far too often in the Church.

All too many unsuspecting people have embraced this fallacy. If we allow the vultures of compromise to peck away at our integrity very soon our message will be but sounding brass and a humanistic gospel!

In every successful army, team, group, outfit and company there are

three very important components at work: **“LEADERS”**, **“FOLLOWERS”**, and **“PURVEYORS OF CHANGE”**.

Let's look at them.

I. LEADERS

A. If people do not know where they are going, any road will get them there.

If people do not know where they stand, then they do not know where they are going.

If people do not stand for something then they will fall for anything.

In my opinion, herein lies one of the greatest obstacles facing the Church. There is a tremendous need for those who have been thrust into a role of leadership to find the direction of the wind of the Spirit, and then flow in that direction.

The text says of the children of Issachar that they were men that had **“understanding of the times to know what Israel ought to do”**. I pray that GOD will make that kind of **“LEADERS”** out of some of you!

I believe that the ability to **“LEAD”** is given in part by the Lord!

However, I am also inclined to believe that the Lord has endued each one of us with the potential of developing our God-given **“LEADERSHIP”** abilities to the desired level!

II Timothy 2:15 **“Study to show thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.”**

If we are to survive in this modern day we must make some adjustments and tailor our Churches to minister to the felt needs of our respective communities.

B. In our text two hundred men headed the work. They were “LEADERS”. Then all their brethren were at their command. These men were singled out by God. They seemed to possess a keen insight concerning the times. They not only had a keen insight, but a broad understanding of how to go about the task.

Their assignment was the proper strategy and logistics. In an army there must be
“LEADERSHIP” and **“FOLLOWSHIP”**!

There must be careful planning on the part of **“LEADERSHIP”**. We must develop a workable **“PLAN”**.

C. I want to encourage each of you who intend to be in **“LEADERSHIP”** at some point to continually ask yourself, **“DO I HAVE A PLAN?”**.

If we are going to be **“CONTEMPORARIES OF ISSACHAR”** you must have a **“PLAN”** that has been given to you by GOD!

If you don’t have a **“PLAN”**, you have a choice. Get on your face before the Lord until you get one, or consider the fact that you may not be called to **“LEADERSHIP”** but **“FOLLOWSHIP”**.

Without proper insight and “LEADERSHIP” the church will end up in pandemonium.

Sometimes the minister supposing to lead the parade, does not have the faintest idea
which direction it took.

God, give us **“LEADERS”** who have a **“PLAN”**!
Give us leaders who will dare to become **“CONTEMPORARIES OF ISSACHAR”**.

“LEADERS!” Lead, follow, or get out of the way!

II. FOLLOWERS

A. Let us look at the beautiful organization under God’s leadership!

In our text it seems that each tribe had its quota of responsibilities. They were working for one united purpose. They did not supplant one another, but rather supplemented each other. These tribes were **“ready armed to the war”** vs. 24. It is said of them that they could **“keep rank”**, they **“were not of a double heart.”** vs. 33

I pray that the God of Heaven will give us people who have got the stomach for the work, people ready to roll up their sleeves and go to work! God, give us **“CONTEMPORARIES OF ISSACHAR!”**

In every successful Church there must be **“LEADERSHIP”** and **“FOLLOWSHIP”**.

There must be careful planning on the part of some.
Then there must be those who will implement this plan.

B. Moses was overworked and over burdened. Then at the suggestion of his father-in-law, he picked seventy men to share in the responsibility.

If you are to have **“LEADERS”** in the Church there must be those who are willing to **“FOLLOW”** the **“LEADERSHIP”** being provided.

I have discovered that if I have a well thought out plan that is bathed in prayer, for the most part, people will be willing to **“FOLLOW”** the **“LEADERSHIP”** being provided.

By the same token, I realize that there have been times when someone in **“LEADERSHIP”** had a plan and the people they were supposed to be leading refused to follow!

In I Cor. 12:28 we find that God has set governments in the church. We need not think it strange when some would break ranks and refuse **“LEADERSHIP”**. The apostle Peter describes these kind of folks in II Peter 2:10, **“but chiefly them that walk after the flesh in the lust of uncleanness, and DESPISE GOVERNMENT...”**

Many churches and Sunday Schools have been stymied and stunted by this caliber of careless characters who were allowed to occupy positions of leadership.

This would equal to leaving a hound to watch over a nest of eggs or allowing a cat to stand guard over a canary.

What are we to do about people such as this? Pray until they get in or out!

There is an old adage that says, “There are too many chiefs, and not enough Indians.”

Illustration: Dennis Keenan regarding choir director, “The Lord hasn’t spoken to me yet.”

C. God provides the vision to **“LEADERS”** and the ability of implementation to **“FOLLOWERS”**.

Let me just say that one is no more important than the other. The **“LEADER”** can’t lead without **“FOLLOWERS”**. The **“FOLLOWERS”** can’t follow without a **“LEADER”** to set the direction.

If we as a Church will properly empower **“LEADERS”** and then set our face as a flint to **“FOLLOW”** the direction the Holy Spirit is guiding the **“LEADER”**, I promise you that this District will take some of the greatest steps forward that this movement has ever witnessed!

I realize that there are some of you sitting there saying, “What if the person doing the **leading** is out of sync? **PRAY**. God has always dealt with **“LEADERS”** who were not in step with His will.

III. PURVEYORS OF CHANGE

A. There seems to be a woeful decline in Sunday School emphasis and attendance.

There is a lack of appreciation for the fundamental teaching of the Word of God.

Some have minimized the importance of Sunday School. There is a danger here. Some have emphasized worship at the expense of teaching.

This can only result in spiritual pride and top heaviness. Many have toppled and have fallen because there was no foundation to build on. This is like building the roof first when the foundation should and must come first.

If you are going to build a Church that will endure, the preaching and teaching of the Word of God must become the **centerpiece** of every service.

It is not an “EITHER, OR” question between teaching and worship, but rather a “BOTH, AND”.

Remember, God has set teachers in the church. I Cor. 12:28, “**and God hath set some in the church, first apostles, secondarily prophets, thirdly teachers, after that miracles, then gifts of healings, helps, governments, diversities of tongues.**”

Ephesians 4:11, “**and he gave some, apostles, and some prophets;**

and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers;”

Notice Isaiah 28:9, **“Whom shall he teach knowledge? and whom shall he make to understand doctrine? them that are weaned from the milk, and drawn from the breasts.”**

B. The times demand proper innovation in the Church.

While the message must never be compromised nor our conscience violated, yet our methods must be commensurate with modern times. We must stay abreast and up to date in our methods.

Our master teacher sometimes sat down and taught. He taught in the synagogue, the market place, and mountain top.

He used for a pulpit a well curb and a fishing boat.

He spoke like no other man spoke. While the Pharisees spoke from authority, He spoke

WITH authority. Theirs was an echo, His was a VOICE.

He wove into His teaching the simple, mundane, routine every day examples. It may have been a bird, a fox, an old hen with chickens, a fishing net, or the sower, seed and soil.

Jesus spoke to people in the realm of their own interest. He, with His spiritual mind, could use these mundane matters to bring out spiritual truth.

C. Results will only occur in our ministry when we PRAY and spend time ALONE with God.

Ours is a SPIRITUAL battle. Natural psychological reasoning will not bring spiritual remedies. Spiritual battles must be fought with spiritual warfare. The power of God is not transmitted by argument. Logical persuasion is not the answer. There must be that convicting and convincing power of the Holy Spirit to walk along beside us and help

us. We need that divine strategy and spiritual logistics in order to accomplish God's plan for us and to usher in our King.

I realize that some would cry out against this statement and argue for the old methods. Some folks are wanting someone to take the Church back to the GOOD OLD DAYS.

I want to tell you tonight, that it is not the will of God for the Church to go backwards, but to move forward and do whatever is necessary to reach our generation! God, give us people who will dare to become **“CONTEMPORARIES OF ISSACHAR”**.

It is my opinion that each Church should involve themselves in the “Teacher Certification” plan offered by the District Christian Education department, called **ACTS EXPRESS**.

We must see to it that those who are teaching our children are all speaking the same thing. We must also see to it that they have properly qualified themselves!

To those who are constantly clamoring for the GOOD OLD DAYS, let me ask you some questions:

Do you want to use the old kerosene lamp, and the smoky barn lantern to light your home and Church?”

Would you like to trade your refrigerator for the good old ice box?

Would you like to go back to horse and buggy days and farm with a one horse plow?

I realize that the principles of salvation cannot be touched by innovation, but there is nothing wrong with the innovation of methods in order to be more effective in bringing souls into the kingdom and ushering in the King of kings.

According to Matthew 24:14, it is when this **“gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; then shall the end come.”**

I believe that any legitimate method of propagating the gospel will be smiled on by our Lord.

Why don't we go back to our respective churches and tell the **“LEADERSHIP”** of our Church that we have decided to **“FOLLOW”** the leadership that God is providing?

If you do, get ready for two things: 1) CHANGE and 2) GROWTH

My prayer tonight is that God will give us **“CONTEMPORARIES OF ISSACHAR”** in each church, and that we will become a New Testament church, and that as a result, **“GOD WILL ADD TO THE CHURCH DAILY SUCH AS SHOULD BE SAVED”!**